# Anger

Most people feel angry sometimes, but if it's affecting your life, there are things you can try that may help.

Support is also available if you're finding it hard to cope with stress, anxiety or depression.

## Symptoms of anger

Anger can cause many different symptoms. It might affect how you feel physically or mentally, or how you behave.

Some people become aggressive towards others when they're angry. Other people hide their anger and may take it out on themselves.

It's not always easy to recognise when anger is the reason why you're behaving differently.

Physical symptoms
Mental symptoms
Changes in behaviour

## Things you can try to help with anger

Do

try to recognise when you start to feel angry so you can take steps to calm down as early as possible

give yourself time to think before reacting – try counting to 10 and doing calming breathing exercises

talk to people about what's making you angry – speak to someone who is not connected to the situation, such as a friend, a GP or a support group such as Samaritans

exercise – activities such as running, walking, swimming and yoga can help you relax and reduce stress

find out how to raise your self-esteem, including how to be more assertive

consider peer support, where people use their experiences to help others. Find out more about peer support on the Mind website

listen to free mental wellbeing audio guides

try self-help cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) techniques on the Every Mind Matters website to manage unhelpful thoughts, reframe situations, solve problems and deal with stress

Don’t

do not try to do everything at once; set small targets you can easily achieve

do not focus on things you cannot change. Focus your time and energy on helping yourself feel better

try not to tell yourself that you're alone – most people feel angry sometimes and support is available

try not to use alcohol, cigarettes, gambling or drugs to relieve anger – these can all contribute to poor mental health

Further information and support
Mind: coping with long-term anger
Mind: treatment and support
Where to get help for anger
See a GP if:
you feel you need help dealing with your anger
They may be able to refer you to a local anger-management programme or counselling.

Anger management programmes
A typical anger management programme may involve 1-to-1 counselling and working in a small group.

A programme may be a 1-day or weekend course, or over a couple of months.

The structure of the programme depends on who provides it, but most programmes include cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT), as well as counselling.

There are also private courses and therapists who can help with anger issues. Make sure any therapist you see is registered with a professional organisation, such as the British Association for Counselling & Psychotherapy.

Where to get NHS help for stress, anxiety or depression
Referring yourself for therapy
If you need more support, you can get free talking therapies, such as cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT), on the NHS.

You can refer yourself directly to a talking therapies service without a referral from a GP.

Find NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression
If you're under 18, or want to get help for someone under 18, find out how to get mental health support for children and young people.

See a GP if:
you're struggling to cope with stress, anxiety or depression

you've had a low mood for more than 2 weeks
things you're trying yourself are not helping
you would prefer to get a referral from a GP
Ask for an urgent GP appointment or call 111 if:
you need help urgently, but it's not an emergency
111 can tell you the right place to get help if you need to see someone. Go to NHS 111 online or call 111

Call 999 or go to A&E now if:
you or someone you know needs immediate help
you have seriously harmed yourself – for example, by taking a drug overdose
A mental health emergency should be taken as seriously as a medical emergency.

Find your nearest A&E

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

Causes of anger
There are many different causes of anger and it's different for everyone.

Some common things that make people feel angry include:

being treated unfairly and feeling powerless to do anything about it
feeling threatened or attacked
other people not respecting your authority, feelings or property
being interrupted when you're trying to achieve a goal
How you react to anger can depend on lots of things, including:

the situation you're in at the moment – if you're dealing with lots of problems or stress, you may find it harder to control your anger
your family history – you may have learned unhelpful ways of dealing with anger from the adults around you when you were a child
events in your past – people who experience traumatic, frightening or stressful events sometimes develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) which can lead to angry outbursts
substances such as drugs and alcohol – which make some people act more aggressively than usual
Some of the things that make you angry may not bother other people at all.

You might find it hard to explain why you feel this way but talking to someone could help you find a solution.

Find out about the 5 steps to mental wellbeing.

Important
If uncontrolled anger leads to domestic violence and abuse (violence or threatening behaviour within a relationship), there are places that offer help and support.

You can contact organisations such as:

Refuge
Women's Aid
Alternatives to Violence Project (AVP)
Men's Advice Line